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r/GameAudio • 13y ago
UnexpectedUppercut

Professional Sound Designers: How do you make those fantastical, magical and/or sci-fi sounds?

To call myself an amateur sound designer would be pretty charitable but I'm learning. I've been playing a lot of FF XIV lately and have been paying particularly close attention to the sound effects and that got me to thinking, "How exactly do they make these sounds?"

In my limited experience, I've been asked to make monster noises and the sound of flares igniting and burning out (amongst about a hundred other much more mundane sounds), but nothing quite like what I hear when my character uses a special move (fireballs and lightning and all that).

My question is this: How do you make those sorts of sounds? What is your thought process when you're presented with a task that requires you to make something really fantastical/out there?

Thanks.

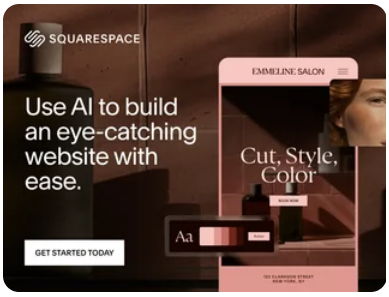
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xxVb • 13y ago

Sometimes it's synths, but I'd say it's more often recorded sound effects from a source (or several), mixed together, processed in different ways. The easiest way to get a monster sound is to take a sound made by a human or animal, and pitch it down. As for fireballs, the sound of fire is usually the sound of the air draft, which you can get from wind (real or artificial) or even your own breath. The sound of lightning strikes is either sampled thunderclaps or some other snappy attack sound, often mixed with an electric-seeming synthetic sound.

But the lightning example is a perfect example of what you do to make up fantastic sounds. How does sustained lightning sound? Nature doesn't do sustained lightning, so you have to be creative. Does it sound like an electric machine, a kind of steady hum? Does it have little spark-y sounds? Does it still sound like thunder up close? Does it have a draft, like fire? Does it sound bassy and powerful, or sharp and erratic, or both, or neither?

You can go the realistic route, try to figure out what something does to the world around it (fire having that air draft), or emphasize a component sound (resin drops exploding and creating those little snap sounds in

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How would a monster contained in a crystal ball (or a crystal ball containing a monster) sound? How would a fireball sound before thrown? How do roots and vines bursting out of the ground sound? How does a living rock creature sound? How does something sound when hitting an energy shield? How does a wyvern sound?

7

UnexpectedUppercut OP • 13y ago

Hrm!

So, for example, how would you go about making the sound of a) an energy field turning on; b) something hitting that field; and c) the energy field dissipating?

1

xxVb • 13y ago

My first thought would be machines that take some time to charge up, like a big professional camera flash. It has this ascending hum while charging, either to communicate that it's charging, or just part of the charge. So that's an obvious choice for anything powering up. It's easily synthesized. This is how Halo's shields sound like.

Stuff hitting the field could have a spark-y, erratic, static-y sound, and probably a thud from something hitting something somewhere in there. It can be a footbag hitting the floor, a foot hitting a table surface, or a baseball bat hitting the sand in a sandbox. An impact sound and a field response sound.

The field dissipating can be a reverse charge, a pitched down sound, like an old tv or tape player that lost power. Rapid or slow, depending on whether it's being shut off or breaks due to an impact. It can also dissipate into those spark-y, erratic, static-y sounds. I would leave a whoosh-like sound of the shield disappearing, maybe something resembling or even based on a big, soft metal plate being hit.

It's not the only idea for an energy field sound, but it's the first that comes to mind. Field visuals might inspire a different sound, like the classic *warehouse lights coming on a few at a time* scene for a shield made out of multiple components (like the beehive design seen in Halo... 2, maybe?).

If I was feeling really ambitious, and could get the sound I wanted to this way, I'd make a synth. Max/MSP, and to a lesser extent, Reaktor, can be used for this. It'd have a power level, some tuning options, and an audio input that can feed it the sounds of things hitting it, thereby letting it react to those. Then I'd just feed different impact sounds to it (sound representing continuous beams, high fire rate projectiles, cannonballs, shrapnel, whatever). That's the ambitious route.

7

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AMillionMonkeys • 13y ago

It's a good idea to have the visual effect accompanying the sound worked out first. Then you can use it as a guide of sorts - especially if the effect has timing that needs to match, like a build up, a sustain and an explosion. Apart from the timing the visuals might give you some ideas about the type of sounds to use.

2

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bits and edit together the necessary envelope for the move.

Without getting into specific effects, fantastical=unnatural, so you get to use your fancy pitched delays, polyphonic pitching plugins and reverse reverbs. Something I like to do is to rapidly automate volume on recorded-out verb tails with the square-wave pencil tool in PT. Gives everything a slightly creepy, mystical feel.

4

UnexpectedUppercut OP • 13y ago

Hrm! I like it. Thanks!

1

BombadeerStudios • 13y ago

Here is a game I worked on several years ago (quality is a bit shitty for listening, unfortunately, but it's the only footage I can find). Most of the spells in this game are based on some sort of physical element that is fairly easy to reproduce through raw audio library material blended together.
Ice = ice crackling/snapping, breaking branches, wind, chimes, breaking glass
Fire = burning, fire movement sounds, explosions
Acid = water, bubbling, hissing (water droplets on a hot plate/wood stove/similar)
lightning = electrical sounds, thunder, explosions
And then in each of them tend to try and spice things up by adding some sort of 'tonal' qualities like deep voices or synth tones, that sort of stuff.
For pure 'arcane' sounds, a lot of time I look for sounds with interesting shapes to them, usually of a tonal nature. Reversed glass shattering or metal hits, after tones of impacts, etc. Reversing and pitching things is a simple way to find an interesting sound texture that isn't always immediately recognizable.
Some people sound design purely with synths and whatnot...I prefer to base my work in real sounds, as I find it helps make them feel more real and impactful.

2

UnexpectedUppercut OP • 13y ago

Wow, cool. Thanks!

1

BombadeerStudios • 13y ago

You're quite welcome, best of luck to you!

1

bananagoo • 13y ago

Layers...lots of layers...lol

2

Chippy569 • 13y ago

This... several things mixed together seems to be the real key. Think of your source sounds as their characteristics and pick ones that meet the spell/effect you want (ie this car rev sounds scary, mechanical,

0 2

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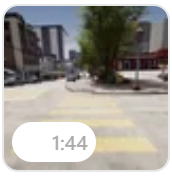
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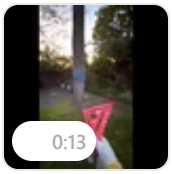
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